

Running Wolfdog

A Short Story by Shay Ginsbourg

To my late grandfather, Meir Kozes

I want to tell you about the running of the wolfdog. What do you call this running of the dog, this running without hope? What do you call this running of the dog, abandoned by treachery on the access road leading to a grove on the edge of the Britannia Park Forest, where he was pushed out from a family car? What do you call this running of the dog, trying with all his might to catch the car, which is driving toward Beit Shemesh but won't stop there? What do you call this running of the dog, the dog who will no longer receive his meals in a bowl, who will no longer wag his tail every time someone takes him for a walk? He will run until exhaustion, and then he will see the car moving away and disappearing. In the afternoon hours, the rain will erase the scents and the rest of the trail marks. The night will fall too quickly. It will be so cold that he will try to warm himself in the bagel position—that position with his nose inside his tail, which gets wet. In the end, he will fall asleep frozen, hungry and thirsty. What do you call this running? About this running I want to tell you.

I remember that sometimes you asked me to sit with Grandfather in the afternoons. I remember that you asked me to teach him to write. I remember that he really wanted to know how to read, that we couldn't progress in the textbook, the book that I had already finished studying long ago. I remember that we always remained on the first page of the book, that he kept trying and couldn't write until his last day. I remember that afterward, they explained on television what dyslexia is, and I understood that this was exactly what Grandfather wrote in our notebook. Scrambled and reversed letters. I told you then.

Oh, my dear grandfather, oh Grandfather, how many beatings did you receive in the classroom, because they didn't understand that you had special needs. My grandfather, how many beatings did you receive. How did they expel you, when they isolated you from the other children, the children who continued to study in the room and afterward were all burned in the extermination camps. Dear grandfather, my grandfather, when did you disappear into the forest and find the wild animals. When did you learn to speak with the wolves. My dear grandfather.

One day, long ago, at least 12,000 years ago, the first wolf came out of the forest. He must have smelled roasted meat at the tribe's campfire. Came out of the forest and smelled roasted meat and approached the tribe. That was also the day when the tribe's people began to learn the language of the wolves. My grandfather certainly knew how to speak in the language of the wolves, but the Holy Scriptures, he couldn't read. They told him he was a gentile. They outcasted him then.

Like in the dark warehouses of Jaffa Port, the walls of my adolescence room were very high and damp. Except that the room's floor was replaced by a blue-black sea carpet, there, in place of the fishermen's boats harbor. Right where a yellow lamp was hanging, the Jaffa lighthouse illuminated me, in endless circles. And every night, there would rage a whirlpool there, drowning my orange bed ship, after it cracked and crashed into a white icy wardrobe. The electric switch would immediately activate gray sirens, which would rise high high above

rusty ladders. A terrifying air raid alarm has frightened me since forever and I would broadcast SOS-SOS-SOS broadcast, broadcast, and be swallowed by rising and falling wave blows, on very high and damp walls. The bookshelf was a narrow slippery deck escape bridge, attached to the southern wall. But every night, there was no respite from the ceiling's beating rains, and a western shutter wind would blow me off the bed deck into the depths, maybe two hours before sunrise. One last thought. One last breath.

One night, my grandfather, bless his memory, reached his hand to me. Pulled me forcefully from the dock to him, to the heavens. He wore a long white robe, like a monk. We walked there together on wide and quiet levels of marble stairs. In the middle of the central level, his new writing desk stood, with many rolled sheets, and an inkwell. I examined his new handwriting carefully. What a wonder! The letters are no longer reversed. Grandfather was very busy writing a new Torah scroll.

My dear grandfather, for the black wolfdog, whom I brought from the "SOS Animals" association, you built a concrete doghouse. You did it without speaking, and afterward you left. Your name we carved on the tombstone, and I still remember how I wanted to teach you to sign. How many times did all the ignoramuses hit you, who called you illiterate, but meant idiot? Tomorrow morning, my body will not float near the sewage outlet at Bat Yam beach. I will be able to walk there barefoot all day on the sand, and remember those hours when I ran there with that black wolfdog. At sunset, we would drink tap water together and gather strength.

I remember that once I was the little child, whose mother was sick, and he only wanted to be with her. I remember how I didn't cry, when I waited for the elevator in line with everyone. But on the way to the ward, I was attacked by a strong scent of disinfectant. Suddenly I was dizzy, and collapsed onto the corridor floor.

True that you showered at home yesterday evening, but you showered at home again this morning, and once more at the hospital. You're trying to sit in the corridor. We're waiting together until they call you. "If they don't let me in until 9:30, then when will they start at all? Only afternoon? I don't want that!" Here it's forbidden to smoke. Must be fasting. Must remove the nail polish with acetone. They still don't know exactly when. Afterward, you don't care at all, that a "No Entry" sign hangs from the ceiling. In my coat pocket, your glasses and watch. We're already inside for almost half an hour, and I'm allowed to quietly go out to the cafeteria, only after the anesthesia.

My grandfather, I adopted a new dog, also a wolfdog, who knows how to speak in the language that you understand. I need for us to meet now so you can see him, how good a dog he is. You would certainly train him differently from me, but I belong to a different generation and with us the rules are different, meaning, it's allowed to do all kinds of things that were once forbidden. You won't like all this freedom, but it's important to me that you know, that I'm also learning the language of the wolves like you. One new word every day.

We quickly receive a small note at the parking lot entrance. Run through the emergency room and then immediately right in the corridor and at the end left according to the signs. On the way there are waiting benches, medical equipment, dirt, noise, families, empty drink cans. Now we must wait until we can talk to someone. It's very worthwhile to find a way to

pass these hours and not think too much. For example, you can observe the child, whose older sister already ran toward the elevator, because they're taking out their father now. He also wants to run and jump on his father, even onto the bed that is currently stopping by the elevator, but he remains standing in his place and screams at the top of his lungs, perhaps because his legs suddenly froze.

I take a green robe from the pile that one of the surgeons threw. I exchange it for another robe and go inside. Like giant helpless babies, everyone is blurry, weak, trembling, casted, bandaged, partially covered. You're not in the first room and there are many more beds here, so one has to search by the pins connecting the skull. Here you are! Do you know where you are? Oh, they braided your hair in braids next to the shaved side. You manage to move all your limbs by yourself, and you remember everything exactly, date, names, addresses, but they shout at me to get out.

You've already seen these people with the awful pins inside their skulls, when you came for urgent consultation with the surgeon and had to pass through the entire ward. And of course you understood yourself that they have to shave the head. No need to shave everything, no need on both sides. But no one, no one prepared you to wake up from the anesthesia with such stupid braids, tied with post office rubber bands. On one hand, for the doctor in the middle of surgery, there's no time to deal with this nonsense, and on the other hand, surely a nurse would have arranged this a bit more aesthetically. You ask me to find your handkerchiefs, and you still can't guess who, because the last time you had braids done, you were maybe 12 years old.

A beloved wolfdog can appear in a dream after passing away. Without any warning, he communicates with me again. Immediately I recognize his voice and a tremor passes through me. One clear thought pierces the consciousness—this time, the conversation must end differently. Where are you? He answers in a whine. Just explain to me where to get to. He continues whining. I bought you special wet food. No answer. I want to take you for a walk at Bat Yam beach. The line disconnects. Usually, at least two- or three-days pass, until I manage to calm down.

Sometimes, I am an orphan child, without a home, without family, begging, looking for food. Without a coat, all filthy, curling into myself and lying motionless on a frosty night near the warehouses of Jaffa Port. Yesterday I was a child, who suckles wolves' milk, speaks the language of animals, and tomorrow I want to be crown prince. My grandfather, I have to tell you, that I'm no longer waiting for the dog that died. I adopted a new wolfdog. He's a good dog, and I want very much only to show him to you. My grandfather, I saved the dog and he saved me.

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